

**"THE MANNER IN WHICH GLOBAL PUBLIC GOOD IS BEING TAKEN FORWARD HAS THE IMPRIMATUR OF THE GLOBAL SOUTH. AND INDIA HAS THE MANTLE OF THAT LEADERSHIP"**

**D.B. VENKATESH VARMA**
*Former Indian ambassador to Russia*



**"IT IS THE LILLIPUTIANS OF THE DEVELOPING WORLD WHO ARE NOW TYING UP GULLIVER AND GETTING HIM TO DEAL WITH THEIR ISSUES FIRST"**

**SYED AKBARUDDIN** *Former Permanent Representative of India to the UN*

excellent logistics and arrangements made for the summit, which the PMO headed by Mishra oversaw, but also because India steered the G20 away from being derailed on the Ukraine issue and the great power games over it. D.B. Venkatesh Varma, a former Indian ambassador to Russia, points out, "Both in symbolism and in substance, the Delhi G20 is a spectacular success for India and Prime Minister Modi. At a time when there was intense flux in the international system, India succeeded in hammering out a consensus on a range of major global issues. It was a power test that India passed with flying colours, which has put the country in the top league, and all this on its own strength. The G20 has been transformed to reflect the aspirations of the Global South and India has taken on the mantle of that leadership." Varma points out that this is both an opportunity and a challenge for India to keep up not only the convergence that it has achieved but its ability to withstand the pressure from great powers as was demonstrated during the G20. For that, Indian diplomacy will be severely tested in the coming years. As S. Jaishankar, the minister for external affairs, put it, "The G20 has contributed to making India world-ready and the world India-ready."

What the Delhi G20 has also done is to set in motion a new and evolving global order. The past decade saw global disorder peak and a breakdown of the Washington consensus for free markets, privatisation and globalisation. Today, the world is beset with such issues as deglobalisation, American withdrawal, growing protectionism, a hostile China and wars over trade, technology, terror and Ukraine. Nations are realising that this dangerous instability in international affairs has to be moderated.

Meanwhile, China has emerged as a major global major power and is challenging the hegemony of the US. The Ukraine war and the Covid pandemic has seen the rise of a multipolar world, with America still all-powerful but China using its rapid economic growth to expand its influence across continents. While China remains a regional military power, economically, it has become a superpower and challenged American dominance. The US has worked towards tying up a host of groupings that could contain China, with India being an integral part of the plan. US President Joe Biden has invested enormous political capital by hosting PM Modi in June, including selling hi-tech military-ware that it doesn't offer even to some of its closest allies. Even at the G20 summit, the two held a bilateral and Biden was all praise for Modi's leadership.

India itself has the task of playing a trapeze artist on the international stage. To do so, even while moving closer to the US to counter the Chinese challenge, India has maintained relations with Russia. It has also succeeded in engaging West Asia, particularly Saudi Arabia and the UAE, as demonstrated by the signing of the groundbreaking India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor for economic integration on the sidelines of the summit. By succeeding in getting the African Union into the G20, India has burnished its image of being a leader of the Global South. On foreign policy, the Modi government played its cards well despite suffering serious setbacks in its relations with China. Addressing the B20 leaders' summit, Jaishankar pointed out that the reason for the sharp focus on the Global South is that these societies are under exceptional stress, especially after the Covid pandemic. It had seriously damaged their economies and disrupted trade, all of which was exacerbated by the fuel and fertiliser shortages caused by the Ukraine war. Jaishankar warned, "If unaddressed, it will become a serious drag on the global economy. Do consider what the implications are for all of us—North or South—of a slowdown in nutrition, health, education, employment or even security. And indeed, when the promise of digitisation, connectivity and technology falls short."

The Delhi G20 summit saw India coalescing the Global South's efforts to bring the issues that matter the most to them to the forefront. Varma says, "The content and the manner in which global public good is being taken forward increasingly has the imprimatur of the Global South and India has played a major role in that. There is a G20 before Delhi and there is a G20 after Delhi." Akbaruddin agrees. "It's the Lilliputians that are now tying up Gulliver and getting him to deal with their issues first." Kant has a point when he says, "What India has done with the G20 is bring multilateralism to the centre stage," he says. It's too early to say how the emerging world order will shape up, but what India has done is succeeded in uniting them in pursuit of the global public good. In the long run, that is a greater binding force than power and pelf. ■